

BEFORE

The Manchu Qing dynasty declined throughout the 19th century, as China increasingly fell under European influence. A period of chaos and rule by regional warlords followed its collapse.

OVERTHROW OF THE MANCHU EMPIRE

In 1905, the political revolutionary, Sun Zhongshan (Sun Yat-sen), founded the Revolutionary Alliance with the aim of **driving out the Manchus** and establishing a republican government in place of monarchical rule. **Nationalist soldiers seized Wuchang** on October 10, 1911, and within weeks south China's provinces had broken away from the empire. When the Manchus asked the commander of the Northern Army, **Yuan Shikai**, for support, he **encouraged the emperor to abdicate**, and in March 1912 he became president of the republic. In January 1916 he accepted an invitation to **become emperor**, but shortly afterward he gave up the position and died.

THE NATIONALIST PARTY

In 1912 the Revolutionary Alliance, led by Sun Zhongshan, became the **Nationalist Party**. Yuan Shikai expelled Nationalist Party members from parliament and they moved south to Guangzhou. There Sun Zhongshan, with help from the Soviet Union, **reorganized the party**. After the death of Sun Zhongshan in 1925, the party's leadership passed gradually to **Jiang Jieshi** (Chiang Kaishek).

WARLORDS FILL THE VOID

From 1916, China had no effective central government and was controlled by **regional warlords**. They included: **Zhang Xun**, the “pigtailed general,” who briefly restored Puyi, the Manchu emperor; **Feng Yuxiang**, the “Christian General,” who barred his troops from gambling; and **Yan Xishan**, the “Model Governor” of Shanxi, who supported educational reform.

THE MAY FOURTH MOVEMENT

On May 4, 1919, it was announced at the Paris Peace Conference **375** that former German colonies in China were to be given to Japan, and major **demonstrations erupted**. The incident gave its name to the radical May Fourth Movement, which **attacked Confucianism** **131**, called for a “literary revolution,” and welcomed a **wave of new ideas**.

CHINESE COMMUNIST PARTY (CCP)

Founded by revolutionaries who had been involved in the May Fourth Movement, the first congress of the CCP was held in July 1921, and was attended by a young Mao Zedong (see right).

“**Communism** is a hammer which we use to **crush the enemy**.”

MAO ZEDONG, 1950



China's Long March

After the fall of the Manchu dynasty in 1911, China experienced a long period of political turmoil. The Nationalists reunified the country, but were frustrated by the 1937 Japanese invasion. The Communists came to power in 1949, and over the next 25 years attempted a revolutionary transformation of society.

In 1923, the Chinese Communist Party formed an uneasy alliance with the Nationalist Party (see BEFORE), and in 1926 supported them in the Northern Expedition to reunify the country. But the alliance collapsed in April 1927, when the Nationalist leader, Jiang Jieshi, ordered hundreds of Communists in Shanghai to be killed.

The Communist leaders fled to the countryside to plan insurrections. Mao Zedong (see right) led a revolt called the Autumn Harvest Uprising, and after defeat by the Nationalists, retreated to the southern province of Jiangxi. There, Mao formulated a new revolutionary

strategy combining the formation of the Red Army—the military arm of the Communists—with land reform, and a promise to emancipate China's women.

The Nanjing decade

Jiang Jieshi's defeat of the Communists strengthened the position of the Nationalist Party, and in 1928 it effectively took control of the country, establishing its capital at Nanjing and reunifying China. Over the next decade,

it reformed the currency, and established modern banks. New schools and colleges were opened, and railroads and roads were improved.



Great endurance

Crossing 18 mountain ranges and 24 major rivers, the Long March lasted 368 days and cost thousands of lives.

The Long March

In October 1934, the Communists abandoned their Jiangxi base, broke through a Nationalist blockade, and began the “Long March” to shake off their enemies. A trek of around 6,200 miles (10,000 km), it took